

Functional Connectivity Targets in PTSD, Ketamine, and Prolonged Exposure

Your design (PTSD + ketamine dose + PE + pre/post resting-state fMRI) is well matched to study specific fronto-limbic and large-scale network connectivity changes that predict or mediate treatment response. Prior work points to a few core circuits with strong justification but room for novel, targeted analyses.

Key Circuits With Strong Justification

1. Amygdala–Hippocampus–vmPFC “Fear Circuit”

- **Ketamine + exposure:** A single ketamine infusion plus brief exposure reduced **amygdala–hippocampus connectivity** without changing amygdala–vmPFC connectivity in PTSD (Duek et al., 2023).
- **Exposure alone:** Prolonged exposure increased **hippocampus–mPFC** and amygdala–orbitofrontal rsFC (Zhu et al., 2018).
- **Potential ROI pairs for your study:**
 - Amygdala–hippocampus
 - Amygdala–vmPFC
 - Hippocampus–vmPFC

These directly test whether ketamine dose modulates extinction-related circuitry beyond PE alone.

2. Salience–Default Mode–Attention Network Interactions

- PTSD shows altered **DMN–dorsal attention** and **salience–dorsal attention** connectivity, and SN–DMN segregation at baseline predicts PE response (Sheynin et al., 2020).
- Large-scale meta-analysis: trauma/PTSD linked to **DMN hypoconnectivity** and abnormal coupling with affective and somatomotor networks (Bao et al., 2021).
- DMN and CEN connectivity also normalize after CBT-type treatments (Vuper et al., 2021) and mindfulness-based exposure (King et al., 2016).

Novel angle: dose-dependent effects of ketamine on **SN–DMN segregation** (e.g., amygdala–PCC; insula–DMN nodes) as moderators of PE response.

3. Thalamocortical and Sensory Networks (More Exploratory)

- Low-dose ketamine alters **thalamocortical connectivity** in depression (Tu et al., 2024) and dynamic rsFC in **visual networks** (Spies et al., 2019).
- PTSD with dissociation and ketamine-induced dissociation both show shifts in **DMN dominance** and reduced somatomotor dominance (Goldway et al., 2025).

Given your design, targeting **thalamus–prefrontal** and **visual/somatomotor–DMN** connectivity as secondary ROIs could yield relatively novel findings in PTSD.

4. Uncinate Fasciculus / Structure–Function Links

- PE-like intensive exposure: early changes in **hippocampus–vmPFC rsFC** correlate with later changes in uncinate fasciculus FA and symptom reduction (Korem et al., 2024).
- Ketamine + exposure also alters uncinate FA (Duek et al., 2023).

You can test whether **changes in fear-circuit rsFC** after PE differ by ketamine dose and predict structural changes (if you have diffusion) or symptom change.

Suggested ROI Pairs and Rationale

Candidate connection	Rationale in PTSD/therapy/ketamine	Citations
Amygdala–hippocampus	Reduced after ketamine+exposure; fear memory updating	(Duek et al., 2023; Zhu et al., 2018)
Hippocampus–vmPFC	Increases after exposure; linked to white-matter change	(Korem et al., 2024; Zhu et al., 2018)
Amygdala–vmPFC	Central to emotion regulation; altered by ketamine, predicts response	(Danböck et al., 2023; Ćurić et al., 2021; Duek et al., 2023)
Amygdala–PCC (SN–DMN)	Lower baseline connectivity predicts PE response	(Sheynin et al., 2020)
PCC / vmPFC–DLPFC (DMN–CEN)	Altered in PTSD; normalize after CBT/mindfulness	(Bao et al., 2021; King et al., 2016; Akiki et al., 2018; Vuper et al., 2021)
Thalamus–prefrontal cortex	Modified by ketamine in TRD; potential biomarker	(Tu et al., 2024; Spies et al., 2019)
Visual networks (intra/interhemispheric)	Robustly affected by ketamine dynamic rsFC	(Spies et al., 2019; Bonhomme et al., 2016)

Figure 1: Possible ROI pairs with justification and sources

Analysis Strategies That Fit Your Sample

- **Seed-to-voxel / ROI-to-ROI rsFC:**
 - Main seeds: bilateral amygdala, hippocampus, vmPFC, PCC, DLPFC, insula, thalamus. (Sheynin et al., 2020; Bao et al., 2021; Ćurić et al., 2021; Korem et

al., 2024; Akiki et al., 2018; Zhu et al., 2018; Tu et al., 2024)- **Change scores and moderation:**

- Test pre→post rsFC changes by group (high-dose vs low-dose vs placebo) and relate to symptom change (responders vs non-responders), mirroring treatment-response work (Sheynin et al., 2020; Ćurić et al., 2021; Korem et al., 2024).
- **Network-level indices (secondary):**
 - DMN/CEN/SN strength, segregation, and DMN–SOM dominance as in PTSD and ketamine dissociation work (Bao et al., 2021; Goldway et al., 2025; Akiki et al., 2018; Bonhomme et al., 2016).

Conclusion

For a thesis that is well grounded yet novel, a focused plan could center on **fronto-limbic and SN–DMN connectivity (amygdala–hippocampus–vmPFC–PCC–insula)** as mediators/moderators of PE response across ketamine doses, with **thalamocortical and visual network connectivity** as exploratory ketamine-specific targets. This builds directly on prior PTSD, exposure therapy, and ketamine imaging findings while asking a new, mechanistic question about how ketamine dose shapes extinction-related connectivity change.

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Ketamine, Brain Connectivity, and PTSD Psychotherapy: Three Novel fMRI-Based Research Questions

Neuroimaging work links PTSD treatment response to changes in **amygdala–prefrontal** circuitry and large-scale networks (default mode, salience, executive) (Sheynin et al., 2020; Zhu et al., 2018; Norbury et al., 2021; Fonzo et al., 2020; Vuper et al., 2021; Fonzo et al., 2017; Hinojosa et al., 2023). Ketamine and exposure-based therapies each modulate these circuits, but they have rarely been mechanistically integrated in one model (Evans et al., 2018; Norbury et al., 2021; Duek et al., 2023). Below are three candidate title questions with rationale, targets, and novelty.

1. Does pre-treatment triple-network segregation predict differential response to ketamine-augmented versus standard exposure therapy in PTSD?

- **Importance/justification:**
Resting-state segregation between **salience (SN)**, **default mode (DMN)**, and **executive/control networks** predicts response to psychotherapy and antidepressant treatment (Sheynin et al., 2020; Lin et al., 2025; Evans et al., 2018; Fonzo et al., 2020; Vuper et al., 2021; Daniels et al., 2010). Identifying which connectivity profile benefits most from ketamine + exposure could personalize care (Sheynin et al., 2020; Lin et al., 2025; Norbury et al., 2021; Vuper et al., 2021).
- **What it examines:**
Baseline rsFC within/between DMN–SN–executive networks and its ability to predict symptom change under (a) prolonged exposure alone vs (b) exposure plus ketamine (Sheynin et al., 2020; Lin et al., 2025; Evans et al., 2018; Norbury et al., 2021; Vuper et al., 2021).
- **Why novel (evidence-based):**
PTSD studies relate rsFC to psychotherapy outcome (Sheynin et al., 2020; Zhu et

al., 2018; Fonzo et al., 2020; Vuper et al., 2021), and ketamine studies show triple-network modulation in MDD/TRD and healthy samples (Mueller et al., 2018; Bonhomme et al., 2016; Lin et al., 2025; Evans et al., 2018; Norbury et al., 2021; Scheidegger et al., 2012). However, no cited work directly tests **network segregation as a moderator** of ketamine-augmented exposure response in PTSD.

2. Does ketamine enhance vmPFC–amygdala inhibitory control during threat processing to a greater degree than exposure therapy alone in PTSD?

- **Importance/justification:**
Improved **vmPFC–amygdala connectivity** and prefrontal control over threat signals predict better outcomes with both ketamine and psychotherapy (Evans et al., 2018; Zhu et al., 2018; Norbury et al., 2021; Fonzo et al., 2017; Chen et al., 2018; Hinojosa et al., 2023). Clarifying whether ketamine specifically boosts this mechanism informs mechanistic, not just symptomatic, augmentation.
 - **What it examines:**
Task-based fMRI (e.g., emotional faces or trauma scripts) assessing changes in effective and functional connectivity between vmPFC and amygdala across treatment arms (Evans et al., 2018; Zhu et al., 2018; Norbury et al., 2021; Duek et al., 2023; Fonzo et al., 2017; Chen et al., 2018; Hinojosa et al., 2023).
 - **Why novel:**
Ketamine in PTSD is linked to increased vmPFC–amygdala connectivity and top-down inhibition (Norbury et al., 2021), and PE alters amygdala–mPFC/hippocampal connectivity (Zhu et al., 2018; Duek et al., 2023; Chen et al., 2018; Hinojosa et al., 2023). No cited trial directly **compares ketamine+exposure vs exposure alone** on this specific inhibitory circuit.
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3. Do ketamine-induced changes in default mode network dominance and somatomotor suppression normalize dissociative brain states in PTSD during psychotherapy?

- **Importance/justification:**
Dissociation in PTSD is tied to abnormal dominance of DMN and reduced somatomotor/meta-states (Zhang et al., 2020; Goldway et al., 2025; Daniels et al., 2010). Dissociation predicts poorer trajectories and may blunt psychotherapy effects (Zhang et al., 2020; Goldway et al., 2025).
- **What it examines:**
Resting-state meta-state dynamics (DMN vs somatomotor dominance, entropy)

before and after ketamine-augmented therapy, and their relation to dissociative symptom change (Sheynin et al., 2020; Zhang et al., 2020; Norbury et al., 2021; Duek et al., 2023; Goldway et al., 2025; Daniels et al., 2010).

- **Why novel:**

Ketamine can induce brain dynamics resembling dissociative PTSD states, with increased DMN dominance (Goldway et al., 2025), and psychotherapies alter DMN/SN/limbic connectivity (Sheynin et al., 2020; Zhu et al., 2018; Fonzo et al., 2020; Vuper et al., 2021). No cited work tests whether **acute ketamine perturbation plus therapy** leads to lasting normalization of dissociative meta-states in PTSD.

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Neurocircuit Targets for Ketamine + Exposure in PTSD: How to Build the Hypotheses

Your three lines of analysis (fronto-limbic circuits, large-scale networks, dynamic connectivity) can be framed as one coherent “mind map” centered on **neuroplasticity in fear/extinction networks**, modulated by ketamine and prolonged exposure (PE).

1. Fronto-Limbic Connectivity (vmPFC–Amygdala–Hippocampus)

Core idea: PE and ketamine both normalize deficient prefrontal control over limbic fear circuitry.

- PE increases **amygdala (BLA/CMA)–orbitofrontal** and **hippocampus–mPFC** rsFC in PTSD, interpreted as better threat reevaluation and memory integration (Zhu et al., 2018).
- Effective connectivity work shows that **stronger mPFC→amygdala inhibition** is a resilience factor, whereas insufficient inhibition predisposes to PTSD (Chen et al., 2018).
- Psychotherapy trials show changes in **amygdala/insula–ventral PFC** connectivity track symptom reduction (Fonzo et al., 2020) and pre-treatment **amygdala–PCC** connectivity predicts response (Sheynin et al., 2020).
- Ketamine in PTSD increases **vmPFC–amygdala connectivity** during emotional processing, with recovery specifically linked to increased top-down vmPFC inhibition of amygdala (Norbury et al., 2021).

Hypothesis 1:

High- vs low-dose ketamine differentially potentiates **vmPFC–amygdala** and

hippocampus–vmPFC connectivity changes produced by PE, and greater normalization of top-down control predicts symptom improvement.

Why MDD → PTSD generalization is reasonable:

In MDD, ketamine's rapid effects depend on **mPFC-centered glutamate-driven plasticity** (AMPA, mTOR, BDNF) (Pham & Gardier, 2019; Kang et al., 2022; Krystal et al., 2023; Abdallah et al., 2018). PTSD also involves **mPFC dysfunction in fear/extinction** and BLA–mPFC NMDA-dependent plasticity (Mavrych et al., 2025; Paredes & Morilak, 2019). Thus, a shared “mPFC plasticity” mechanism plausibly applies across disorders.

2. Large-Scale Network Segregation (DMN, SN, CEN)

Core idea: Treatment works by restoring **segregation and balance** among DMN, salience (SN), and executive (CEN) networks.

- PTSD shows greater **DMN–DAN** and **SN–DAN** connectivity and reduced within-DMN connectivity (Sheynin et al., 2020). High PE responders have **greater SN–DMN segregation** (less amygdala–PCC coupling) and lower network centrality pre-treatment (Sheynin et al., 2020).
- After CBT-type therapies, **DMN and CEN connectivity normalize**, and changes relate to affect and PTSD symptoms (Vuper et al., 2021; Fonzo et al., 2020).
- EEG-fMRI work in PTSD/MDD identifies subtypes distinguished by **frontoparietal–DMN connectivity**, which predict psychotherapy and SSRI response (Zhang et al., 2020).

Hypothesis 2:

Ketamine dose modulates how PE shifts **SN–DMN and DMN–CEN connectivity** (e.g., amygdala/insula–PCC, vmPFC–DLPFC). Greater **restoration of SN–DMN segregation and CEN normalization** will predict better clinical response, especially in those with “connectivity-extreme” subtypes (Sheynin et al., 2020; Zhang et al., 2020; Vuper et al., 2021).

Novelty: Most PTSD therapy papers examine PE or CBT alone (Zhu et al., 2018; Fonzo et al., 2020; Sheynin et al., 2020; Vuper et al., 2021). Testing **dose-dependent ketamine effects on PE-induced network realignment** is new, and justified by transdiagnostic network abnormalities across PTSD and MDD (Zhang et al., 2020; Sheynin et al., 2020; Abdallah et al., 2018).

3. Dynamic Functional Connectivity / Brain States

Core idea: PTSD involves unstable switching between network states; ketamine + PE might stabilize **adaptive “extinction-ready” states**.

- PTSD shows increased variability of DMN nodes (precuneus) and altered dynamic FC between **DMN, SN (insula), and parietal regions** (Fu et al., 2019), and abnormal DMN–cerebellum/visual network state transitions (Dai et al., 2023).

- A large ENIGMA-PGC study finds that simple PTSD vs control contrasts show little dynamic FC difference, implying that **symptom dimensions or comorbidities** (e.g., dissociation, mTBI) better capture instability (Tomas et al., 2025; Dwulit et al., 2025; Shaw et al., 2023).
- Comorbid PTSD+mTBI shows increased SN-related FC variability and longer dwell time in externally focused states, tied to hypervigilance and reduced network segregation (Dwulit et al., 2025).
- Dissociative PTSD subtype exhibits widespread **hyperconnectivity** and divergence from normal small-world organization (Shaw et al., 2023).

Hypothesis 3:

Ketamine dose will influence **dynamic properties** of SN–DMN–CEN interactions (variability, dwell time in segregated vs hyperconnected states). Greater **reduction of SN-centric hypervariability** and more time in well-segregated states after PE will mark better response.

Novelty: Dynamic FC has rarely been linked to treatment response in PTSD, and not to ketamine + PE. Your design can tie **molecular plasticity (from ketamine)** (Wellington et al., 2025; Kang et al., 2022; Krystal et al., 2023; Abdallah et al., 2018) to **network-level stabilization** during extinction learning.

Conclusion

Together, these hypotheses form a hierarchical mind map:

ketamine-induced **mPFC plasticity** → improved **vmPFC–amygdala/hippocampus connectivity** → restoration of **SN–DMN–CEN organization** (static and dynamic) → better PE-based extinction and symptom reduction. The novelty lies in testing **dose-dependent ketamine enhancement of PE** across all three levels in PTSD, using mechanistic bridges established in both PTSD and MDD literatures.

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Ketamine Dose, Network Segregation, and Exposure Therapy in PTSD

Proposed research question (title-style):

“Does ketamine dose modulate salience–default mode network segregation to enhance response to prolonged exposure therapy in PTSD?”

Why the assumptions are reasonable and backed by prior work

1. **PTSD shows abnormal SN–DMN connectivity:**
PTSD patients have greater **SN–DMN and DMN–attention** connectivity and reduced within-DMN connectivity at rest, indicating desegregation of large-scale networks (Sheynin et al., 2020; Daniels et al., 2010).
2. **Greater SN–DMN segregation predicts better psychotherapy response:**
In a randomized PTSD trial, higher responders had **less amygdala–PCC connectivity** (more SN–DMN segregation) and lower global centrality before treatment (Sheynin et al., 2020).
3. **Exposure therapies change limbic–prefrontal and network connectivity:**
Prolonged exposure increases **amygdala/hippocampus–prefrontal** rsFC (Zhu et al., 2018) and decreases limbic–frontoparietal connectivity (Fonzo et al., 2020); CBT-type therapies normalize **DMN/CEN** connectivity (Vuper et al., 2021).
4. **Ketamine modulates DMN/SN connectivity and triple networks:**
Ketamine alters **DMN–salience** coupling and DMN hubs in depression and healthy volunteers (Evans et al., 2018; Mueller et al., 2018; Bonhomme et al., 2016; Scheidegger et al., 2012; Zacharias et al., 2019; Lin et al., 2025). In PTSD, ketamine plus brief exposure reduces **amygdala–hippocampus connectivity** and affects uncinate fasciculus structure (Duek et al., 2023), and repeated-dose ketamine enhances **vmPFC–amygdala control** linked to symptom improvement (Norbury et al., 2021).

These findings support the assumptions that:

- SN–DMN segregation is a meaningful marker for PTSD treatment response (Sheynin et al., 2020).
- Both exposure and ketamine act on overlapping fronto-limbic and triple-network circuits (Zhu et al., 2018; Norbury et al., 2021; Fonzo et al., 2020; Vuper et al., 2021; Evans et al., 2018; Duek et al., 2023; Lin et al., 2025).
- Ketamine's network effects are dose-dependent in other disorders (Lin et al., 2025; Mueller et al., 2018; Scheidegger et al., 2012), making a dose–network–outcome relationship plausible.

What the question examines (operationally)

- **Main construct:** Resting-state **segregation vs desegregation** between salience (amygdala, insula), DMN (vmPFC, PCC), and frontoparietal control regions.
- **Design leverage in your data:**
 - Group factor: **high-dose vs low-dose ketamine vs placebo**, all receiving prolonged exposure.
 - Time: pre vs post-treatment resting-state scans.
- **Analyses you could run:**
 - ROI-to-ROI/seed-based rsFC for **amygdala–PCC, insula–PCC, vmPFC–amygdala**, and network-level indices (SN–DMN connectivity

strength, modularity) (Sheynin et al., 2020; Zhu et al., 2018; Norbury et al., 2021; Fonzo et al., 2020; Vuper et al., 2021; Evans et al., 2018; Duek et al., 2023; Mueller et al., 2018; Scheidegger et al., 2012).

- Test whether **pre-treatment SN–DMN segregation** predicts symptom change differently by ketamine dose (moderation) (Sheynin et al., 2020; Norbury et al., 2021).
- Test whether **change in SN–DMN segregation** mediates the effect of ketamine dose on clinical improvement (mediation) (Sheynin et al., 2020; Zhu et al., 2018; Norbury et al., 2021; Fonzo et al., 2020; Duek et al., 2023).

Core connections of interest and rationale

Connectivity / Metric	Rationale in PTSD / ketamine / therapy	Citations
Amygdala–PCC (SN–DMN)	Less baseline connectivity → better PE response	(Sheynin et al., 2020)
Insula–DMN hubs (PCC/vmPFC)	Triple-network dysfunction and ketamine effects	(Sheynin et al., 2020; Fonzo et al., 2020; Evans et al., 2018; Mueller et al., 2018; Bonhomme et al., 2016)
vmPFC–amygdala	Ketamine-related improvement & prefrontal control	(Norbury et al., 2021; Zhu et al., 2018; Chen et al., 2018; Fonzo et al., 2017; Hinojosa et al., 2023)
DMN/CEN graph metrics (centrality, path length)	Predict treatment effects; altered by ketamine	(Sheynin et al., 2020; Vuper et al., 2021; Lin et al., 2025; Mueller et al., 2018; Scheidegger et al., 2012)

Figure 1: Key connectivity targets linking networks to outcome

Why this is novel

- Existing PTSD treatment studies link **rsFC or activation** to psychotherapy response but do not include **ketamine dose manipulation within the same exposure protocol** (Sheynin et al., 2020; Zhu et al., 2018; Fonzo et al., 2020; Vuper et al., 2021; Fonzo et al., 2017; Hinojosa et al., 2023).
- Ketamine studies in PTSD and depression show circuit changes (e.g., vmPFC–amygdala, DMN hubs), but generally **without structured exposure therapy** or without examining SN–DMN segregation as a mechanistic moderator/mediator (Norbury et al., 2021; Evans et al., 2018; Duek et al., 2023; Lin et al., 2025; Mueller et al., 2018; Scheidegger et al., 2012).
- The combination of:
 - explicit **dose comparison** (high vs low vs placebo),
 - **pre/post PE** design, and

- a **triple-network, segregation-focused connectivity model** (Sheynin et al., 2020; Fonzo et al., 2020; Vuper et al., 2021; Evans et al., 2018; Lin et al., 2025) appears absent from the cited literature, giving strong but still underexplored mechanistic grounding.

Scientific value

1. Toward personalized PTSD treatment:

If higher SN–DMN segregation predicts better response specifically in ketamine-augmented PE, this could identify which patients should receive ketamine vs PE alone (Sheynin et al., 2020; Norbury et al., 2021; Fonzo et al., 2017; Zhang et al., 2020).

2. Mechanistic understanding of augmentation:

Showing that ketamine dose systematically increases (or normalizes) SN–DMN segregation, and that these changes mediate better PE outcomes, would tie molecular intervention (NMDA blockade) to **network-level learning/extinction mechanisms** (Zhu et al., 2018; Norbury et al., 2021; Fonzo et al., 2020; Evans et al., 2018; Duek et al., 2023; Lin et al., 2025).

3. Bridging single-treatment literatures:

This question integrates:

- fear-circuit changes with PE (Zhu et al., 2018; Duek et al., 2023),
- prefrontal–amygdala control under ketamine (Norbury et al., 2021; Chen et al., 2018), and
- triple-network models of psychopathology (Sheynin et al., 2020; Fonzo et al., 2020; Vuper et al., 2021; Evans et al., 2018; Lin et al., 2025; Mueller et al., 2018).

Demonstrating a unifying network principle (SN–DMN segregation) could motivate transdiagnostic, network-based biomarkers.

4. Network-level biomarker candidate:

Replicating and extending the finding that **greater SN–DMN segregation and lower global centrality** predict better outcomes (Sheynin et al., 2020) in a ketamine-PE context would strengthen these metrics as robust biomarkers, with potential to generalize to other trauma interventions or neuromodulation (Sheynin et al., 2020; Fonzo et al., 2020; Vuper et al., 2021; Zhang et al., 2020).

Background to start your project

● PTSD connectivity at baseline:

PTSD is linked to **greater DMN–dorsal attention and SN–DAN connectivity** and decreased within-DMN connectivity (Sheynin et al., 2020; Daniels et al., 2010), plus impaired switching between DMN and executive networks (Daniels et al., 2010).

Trauma-exposed resilient individuals show stronger **mPFC inhibition of amygdala**

than PTSD patients, suggesting a resilience phenotype (Chen et al., 2018).

- **Effects of trauma-focused psychotherapy:**

Prolonged exposure increases **amygdala/hippocampus–prefrontal rsFC**, likely reflecting better threat inhibition and memory integration (Zhu et al., 2018). Other CBTs normalize **CEN and DMN** connectivity and link changes in DMN/SN to affect and PTSD symptom improvements (Fonzo et al., 2020; Vuper et al., 2021). Exposure outcome is also influenced by pre-treatment vmPFC–amygdala balance and amygdala habituation (Fonzo et al., 2017; Hinojosa et al., 2023).

- **Ketamine’s large-scale network effects:**

In depression and healthy subjects, ketamine reduces **DMN hub connectivity** and alters **DMN–salience interactions**, with changes in insula–DMN coupling and prefrontal DMN connectivity (Evans et al., 2018; Mueller et al., 2018; Bonhomme et al., 2016; Scheidegger et al., 2012; Zacharias et al., 2019). Trials in TRD show ketamine-related modulation of DMN, salience, and frontoparietal network graph metrics, consistent with a **triple-network model** (Lin et al., 2025).

- **Ketamine + PTSD:**

Repeated-dose ketamine in PTSD: improvement is associated with **increased vmPFC–amygdala connectivity during emotional processing**, increased vmPFC–insula connectivity, and stronger **top-down vmPFC inhibition of amygdala**, particularly under ketamine (Norbury et al., 2021).

Post-retrieval ketamine + brief exposure: reduced **amygdala activation to trauma scripts**, decreased **amygdala–hippocampus connectivity**, and changes in uncinate fasciculus FA, suggesting modification of fear memory circuits (Duek et al., 2023).

A dissociative ketamine challenge in PTSD acutely decreased vmPFC–amygdala rsFC rather than increasing it, indicating that acute and therapeutic patterns may differ and need careful timing consideration (Danböck et al., 2023).

Combining these strands, your project can test whether **ketamine dose shapes the large-scale network “starting point” and plasticity window** within which prolonged exposure works, focusing on **SN–DMN segregation** as the mechanistic bridge from drug to therapy response.

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 - Test whether **change in SN–DMN segregation** mediates the effect of ketamine dose on clinical improvement (mediation) (Sheynin et al. 2020, 1037 - 1046; Zhu et al. 2018, 974 - 984; Norbury et al. 2021, 2266 - 2277; Fonzo et al. 2020, 857 - 867; Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658).

Core connections of interest and rationale

Connectivity / Metric	Rationale in PTSD / ketamine / therapy	Citations
Amygdala–PCC (SN–DMN)	Less baseline connectivity → better PE response	(Sheynin et al. 2020, 1037 - 1046)
Insula–DMN hubs (PCC/vmPFC)	Triple-network dysfunction and ketamine effects	(Sheynin et al. 2020, 1037 - 1046; Fonzo et al. 2020, 857 - 867; Evans et al. 2018, 582 - 590; Mueller et al. 2018, 745 - 757; Bonhomme et al. 2016, 873–888)
vmPFC–amygdala	Ketamine-related improvement & prefrontal control	(Norbury et al. 2021, 2266 - 2277; Zhu et al. 2018, 974 - 984; Chen et al. 2018; Fonzo et al. 2017, 1163 - 1174; Hinojosa et al. 2023)
DMN/CEN graph metrics (centrality, path length)	Predict treatment effects; altered by ketamine	(Sheynin et al. 2020, 1037 - 1046; Vuper et al. 2021, 113312 - 113312; Lin et al. 2025, 766 - 774; Mueller et al. 2018, 745 - 757; Scheidegger et al. 2012)

Figure 1: Key connectivity targets linking networks to outcome

Why this is novel

- Existing PTSD treatment studies link **rsFC or activation** to psychotherapy response but do not include **ketamine dose manipulation within the same exposure protocol** (Sheynin et al. 2020, 1037 - 1046; Zhu et al. 2018, 974 - 984; Fonzo et al. 2020, 857 - 867; Vuper et al. 2021, 113312 - 113312; Fonzo et al. 2017, 1163 - 1174; Hinojosa et al. 2023).
- Ketamine studies in PTSD and depression show circuit changes (e.g., vmPFC–amygdala, DMN hubs), but generally **without structured exposure therapy** or without examining SN–DMN segregation as a mechanistic moderator/mediator (Norbury et al. 2021, 2266 - 2277; Evans et al. 2018, 582 - 590; Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658; Lin et al. 2025, 766 - 774; Mueller et al. 2018, 745 - 757; Scheidegger et al. 2012).
- The combination of:
 - explicit **dose comparison** (high vs low vs placebo),
 - **pre/post PE** design, and
 - a **triple-network, segregation-focused connectivity model** (Sheynin et al. 2020, 1037 - 1046; Fonzo et al. 2020, 857 - 867; Vuper et al. 2021, 113312 - 113312; Evans et al. 2018, 582 - 590; Lin et al. 2025, 766 - 774) appears absent from the cited literature, giving strong but still underexplored mechanistic grounding.

Scientific value

1. **Toward personalized PTSD treatment:**

If higher SN–DMN segregation predicts better response specifically in ketamine-augmented PE, this could identify which patients should receive ketamine vs PE alone (Sheynin et al. 2020, 1037 - 1046; Norbury et al. 2021, 2266 - 2277; Fonzo et al. 2017, 1163 - 1174; Zhang et al. 2020).
2. **Mechanistic understanding of augmentation:**

Showing that ketamine dose systematically increases (or normalizes) SN–DMN segregation, and that these changes mediate better PE outcomes, would tie molecular intervention (NMDA blockade) to **network-level learning/extinction mechanisms** (Zhu et al. 2018, 974 - 984; Norbury et al. 2021, 2266 - 2277; Fonzo et al. 2020, 857 - 867; Evans et al. 2018, 582 - 590; Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658; Lin et al. 2025, 766 - 774).
3. **Bridging single-treatment literatures:**

This question integrates:

 - fear-circuit changes with PE (Zhu et al. 2018, 974 - 984; Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658),
 - prefrontal–amygdala control under ketamine (Norbury et al. 2021, 2266 - 2277; Chen et al. 2018), and
 - triple-network models of psychopathology (Sheynin et al. 2020, 1037 - 1046; Fonzo et al. 2020, 857 - 867; Vuper et al. 2021, 113312 - 113312; Evans et al.

2018, 582 - 590; Lin et al. 2025, 766 - 774; Mueller et al. 2018, 745 - 757).
Demonstrating a unifying network principle (SN–DMN segregation) could motivate transdiagnostic, network-based biomarkers.

4. **Network-level biomarker candidate:**

Replicating and extending the finding that **greater SN–DMN segregation and lower global centrality** predict better outcomes (Sheynin et al. 2020, 1037 - 1046) in a ketamine-PE context would strengthen these metrics as robust biomarkers, with potential to generalize to other trauma interventions or neuromodulation (Sheynin et al. 2020, 1037 - 1046; Fonzo et al. 2020, 857 - 867; Vuper et al. 2021, 113312 - 113312; Zhang et al. 2020).

Background to start your project

- **PTSD connectivity at baseline:**

PTSD is linked to **greater DMN–dorsal attention and SN–DAN connectivity** and decreased within-DMN connectivity (Sheynin et al. 2020, 1037 - 1046; Daniels et al. 2010, 258-66), plus impaired switching between DMN and executive networks (Daniels et al. 2010, 258-66). Trauma-exposed resilient individuals show stronger **mPFC inhibition of amygdala** than PTSD patients, suggesting a resilience phenotype (Chen et al. 2018).

- **Effects of trauma-focused psychotherapy:**

Prolonged exposure increases **amygdala/hippocampus–prefrontal rsFC**, likely reflecting better threat inhibition and memory integration (Zhu et al. 2018, 974 - 984). Other CBTs normalize **CEN and DMN** connectivity and link changes in DMN/SN to affect and PTSD symptom improvements (Fonzo et al. 2020, 857 - 867; Vuper et al. 2021, 113312 - 113312). Exposure outcome is also influenced by pre-treatment vmPFC–amygdala balance and amygdala habituation (Fonzo et al. 2017, 1163 - 1174; Hinojosa et al. 2023).

- **Ketamine’s large-scale network effects:**

In depression and healthy subjects, ketamine reduces **DMN hub connectivity** and alters **DMN–salience interactions**, with changes in insula–DMN coupling and prefrontal DMN connectivity (Evans et al. 2018, 582 - 590; Mueller et al. 2018, 745 - 757; Bonhomme et al. 2016, 873–888; Scheidegger et al. 2012; Zacharias et al. 2019, 107 - 119). Trials in TRD show ketamine-related modulation of DMN, salience, and frontoparietal network graph metrics, consistent with a **triple-network model** (Lin et al. 2025, 766 - 774).

- **Ketamine + PTSD:**

Repeated-dose ketamine in PTSD: improvement is associated with **increased vmPFC–amygdala connectivity during emotional processing**, increased vmPFC–insula connectivity, and stronger **top-down vmPFC inhibition of amygdala**, particularly under ketamine (Norbury et al. 2021, 2266 - 2277).

Post-retrieval ketamine + brief exposure: reduced **amygdala activation to trauma scripts**, decreased **amygdala–hippocampus connectivity**, and changes in

uncinate fasciculus FA, suggesting modification of fear memory circuits (Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658).

A dissociative ketamine challenge in PTSD acutely decreased vmPFC–amygdala rsFC rather than increasing it, indicating that acute and therapeutic patterns may differ and need careful timing consideration (Danböck et al. 2023, 243 - 252).

Combining these strands, your project can test whether **ketamine dose shapes the large-scale network “starting point” and plasticity window** within which prolonged exposure works, focusing on **SN–DMN segregation** as the mechanistic bridge from drug to therapy response.

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With fMRIPrep + Nilearn Outputs, What Can You Do?

With whole-brain, preprocessed data and connectivity matrices (no predefined ROIs), you can perform a wide range of **data-driven and ROI/network-based** functional connectivity analyses. The papers below show the main families of methods that match exactly what you have.

1. Whole-Brain, Atlas-Based Static Connectivity

Using an atlas (e.g., AAL, functional atlases), you can:

- Extract mean time series per region and build **region×region correlation matrices** (Pearson/Fisher-z) (Chen et al. 2023; Jin et al. 2017; Akiki et al. 2018, 489 - 498).
- Compute **graph-theory measures** (degree, efficiency, clustering, small-worldness) and compare groups or time points (Chen et al. 2023; Wright et al. 2022; Akiki et al. 2018, 489 - 498; Van Den Heuvel and Pol 2010, 519-34).

This is feasible directly from your existing connectivity outputs (Nilearn can build these matrices) and is standard in PTSD and other disorders (Chen et al. 2023; Jin et al. 2017; Wright et al. 2022; Akiki et al. 2018, 489 - 498; Van Den Heuvel and Pol 2010, 519-34).

Example options

- PTSD vs control / pre vs post therapy differences in whole-brain connectivity strength.
- Nodal metrics for DMN, salience, and executive regions (Chen et al. 2023; Jin et al. 2017; Akiki et al. 2018, 489 - 498).

2. Seed-Based and ROI-to-ROI Analyses

Even without predefined ROIs, you can define:

- **Data-driven seeds** from ICA components or atlas regions, then do seed-to-voxel / ROI-to-ROI correlations (Neha and Gandhi 2016, 2551-2554; Wemheuer et al. 2026; Kumar et al. 2020, 157 - 165; Metwali and Samii 2019).
- Examine specific networks (DMN, salience, visual, etc.) using seed-based connectivity (Neha and Gandhi 2016, 2551-2554; Wemheuer et al. 2026; Kumar et al. 2020, 157 - 165; Metwali and Samii 2019).

Nilearn + fMRIPrep are explicitly used for this kind of ROI/seed-based analysis in clinical populations (Wemheuer et al. 2026; Zhang et al. 2020).

3. Independent Component Analysis (ICA) and Dual Regression

You can:

- Run **group ICA** to identify resting-state networks in a fully data-driven way (Tomas et al. 2025; Dai et al. 2023, 294-305; Neha and Gandhi 2016, 2551-2554; Ambrosi et al. 2026).
- Use **dual regression** to obtain subject-specific spatial maps and time series per component, then test group/pre-post differences in:
 - Network **shape/topography**
 - Network **amplitude** (Tomas et al. 2025; Nickerson et al. 2017).

This leverages whole-brain data without any prior ROI choice and is standard in PTSD dynamic FC work (Tomas et al. 2025; Dai et al. 2023, 294-305).

4. Dynamic Functional Connectivity (dFC)

Your full time series allow:

- Sliding-window or adaptive-window **dynamic FC** to identify recurring connectivity “states” and their **dwell time / number of transitions** (Tomas et al. 2025; Dai et al. 2023, 294-305; Jin et al. 2017; Fu et al. 2019).
- Metrics of **temporal variability** (variance of FC over time) at local and large-scale levels (Fu et al. 2019; Jin et al. 2017).

Studies show dynamic FC can be **more sensitive** than static FC for PTSD classification and resilience prediction (Dai et al. 2023, 294-305; Jin et al. 2017; Kundu et al. 2021, 529 - 542).

Different Dynamic Metrics You Can Compute

Analysis type	What you estimate	Papers
---------------	-------------------	--------

Windowed correlation + k-means	Recurrent FC “states”, dwell time, transitions	(Tomas et al. 2025; Dai et al. 2023, 294-305; Jin et al. 2017; Fu et al. 2019)
Variability of FC over time	Std/variance of edges or nodal FC	(Fu et al. 2019; Dai et al. 2023, 294-305; Jin et al. 2017; Kundu et al. 2021, 529 - 542)
Graph metrics over time	Time-varying efficiency, clustering, etc.	(Dai et al. 2023, 294-305; Kundu et al. 2021, 529 - 542)

Figure 1: Main static and dynamic connectivity options with your data

5. Multimodal / Machine-Learning Extensions (If You Add More)

If you also have diffusion or EEG, there are examples of:

- **SC-guided dynamic FC** to predict PTSD resilience (Kundu et al. 2021, 529 - 542).
- **Subtype discovery / treatment prediction** from whole-brain connectivity patterns using machine learning (Wright et al. 2022; Zhang et al. 2020; Jin et al. 2017; Dwulit et al. 2025).

These approaches still start from the same kind of whole-brain FC matrices and ICA outputs you already have.

Conclusion

With fMRIPrep + Nilearn outputs and no preset ROIs, you can robustly do: (1) atlas-based whole-brain static FC and graph theory; (2) seed-based and ROI-to-ROI analyses; (3) ICA + dual regression for network-level changes; and (4) multiple forms of dynamic FC. All are well supported in PTSD and broader psychiatric literature, and your dataset is technically compatible with each.

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Step-by-step plan to analyse your data

Below is a practical pipeline you can implement with your fMRIPrep + Nilearn outputs to address your research question on ketamine dose, PTSD, and large-scale network connectivity.

1. Clarify design and variables

- **Groups:** High-dose ketamine, low-dose ketamine, placebo (all PTSD).
- **Time:** Pre-treatment (baseline) and post-treatment (after PE).
- **Outcomes:** PTSD symptom scores (e.g., CAPS), responder/non-responder.

This matches resting-state PTSD work that uses pre/post or cross-sectional comparisons with symptoms (Shen et al. 2013, 403 - 415; Akiki et al. 2018, 489 - 498; Fu et al. 2019; Suo et al. 2015).

2. Preprocessing: check and choose denoising

You already have fMRIPrep outputs (Esteban et al. 2018, 111 - 116). Next:

1. Quality control

- Use visual QC for motion, artifacts; exclude very poor scans. HALFpipe shows how standardized QA is integrated after fMRIPrep (Ke et al. 2018, 99 - 110).

2. Confound regression & filtering (Nilearn)

- Follow denoising strategies benchmarked on fMRIPrep outputs: motion parameters, tissue signals, $\pm$ global signal, with or without scrubbing, depending on analysis needs (Wang et al. 2023, e1011942 - e1011942).
 - The fMRIPrep+Nilearn workflow: load preprocessed images, fetch confounds, regress them during time-series extraction, then compute connectomes (Wang et al. 2023, e1011942 - e1011942).
-

3. Choose a brain parcellation

You need nodes to compute connectivity:

- Use an **atlas-based parcellation** (e.g., 100–300 parcels) for whole-brain FC; this improves SNR and reproducibility vs voxelwise (Faria et al. 2012, 613 - 621; Kim et al. 2024; Tomas et al. 2025).
 - You can optionally use **functional atlases** or groupwise parcellations if you want data-driven nodes (Tomas et al. 2025; Kim et al. 2024; Chong et al. 2017, 87 - 100).
-

4. Extract time-series and build static connectomes

For each subject $\times$ timepoint:

1. Time-series extraction

- With Nilearn's **NiftiLabelsMasker** or similar, input:
 - preprocessed BOLD,
 - atlas,
 - confounds from fMRIPrep (Wang et al. 2023, e1011942 - e1011942).

2. Connectivity matrices

- Use Pearson correlation (or partial correlation) to get ROI $\times$ ROI matrices (Faria et al. 2012, 613 - 621; Pervaiz et al. 2019; Suo et al. 2015).
- Fisher-z transform correlations.

You now have a static functional connectome for each scan.

5. Define networks and key connectivity metrics

Grounded in PTSD literature:

- **Networks of interest:**
 - Default mode network (DMN), salience network (SN), central-executive / frontoparietal network (CEN), somatomotor and visual networks (Luppi et al. 2024; Harnett et al. 2021, 1263 - 1271; Craddock et al. 2011; Akiki et al. 2018, 489 - 498; Fu et al. 2019; Suo et al. 2015).
- **Key metrics to compute:**
 - Within-network connectivity (e.g., DMN–DMN strength) (Akiki et al. 2018, 489 - 498; Suo et al. 2015).
 - Between-network connectivity (AN/SN–DMN, DMN–somatomotor, SN–somatomotor) (Luppi et al. 2024; Harnett et al. 2021, 1263 - 1271; Craddock et al. 2011; Akiki et al. 2018, 489 - 498; Fu et al. 2019).
 - Graph-theory properties: global efficiency, clustering, path length, modularity to capture integration/segregation (Akiki et al. 2018, 489 - 498; Suo et al. 2015; Luppi et al. 2024; Harnett et al. 2021, 1263 - 1271).

Use atlas labels or published network assignments to group ROIs into DMN, SN, CEN, etc. (Luppi et al. 2024; Harnett et al. 2021, 1263 - 1271; Akiki et al. 2018, 489 - 498).

6. Group-level static FC analyses

6.1 Baseline predictors (pre-treatment)

- Test whether **pre-treatment SN–DMN connectivity** (e.g., amygdala/insula–PCC regions) predicts symptom change, as in predictive PTSD work (Shen et al. 2013, 403 - 415; Harnett et al. 2021, 1263 - 1271; Akiki et al. 2018, 489 - 498; Fu et al. 2019).
- Model: symptom change ~ baseline connectivity × group (dose).

6.2 Pre→post changes by group

- For each subject, compute $\Delta\text{connectivity} = \text{post} - \text{pre}$ for:
 - Within-DMN, SN, CEN.
 - SN–DMN, DMN–somatomotor, AN–DMN (Luppi et al. 2024; Harnett et al. 2021, 1263 - 1271; Craddock et al. 2011; Akiki et al. 2018, 489 - 498; Fu et al. 2019).
- Use mixed-effects or repeated-measures ANOVA:
 - Factors: Time (pre/post) × Group (high/low/placebo).
- Test whether ketamine dose **modulates change in network segregation/integration**, similar to network-based PTSD and graph-theory work

(Akiki et al. 2018, 489 - 498; Suo et al. 2015; Luppi et al. 2024; Harnett et al. 2021, 1263 - 1271; Bao et al. 2021).

7. Data-driven network analysis (ICA / connectome-wide)

As a complementary, hypothesis-free view:

1. Group ICA

- Run group ICA to derive resting-state components (DMN, ECN, SN, visual, etc.) (Tomas et al. 2025; Craddock et al. 2011; Ke et al. 2018, 99 - 110).
- Use dual regression or similar to get subject-specific maps and time-series (Tomas et al. 2025; Craddock et al. 2011).

2. Network-level measures

- Compare intranetwork and internetwork connectivity (DMN, ECN, SN) pre/post and by group, as in typhoon-related PTSD ICA work (Craddock et al. 2011).
- Optionally, run **connectome-wide** tests (e.g., network-based statistics or MDMR) to identify edges whose connectivity differs by group or change with treatment (Misaki et al. 2017, 285 - 296; Akiki et al. 2018, 489 - 498).

This captures effects beyond your a priori ROIs (Tomas et al. 2025; Misaki et al. 2017, 285 - 296).

8. Dynamic functional connectivity (optional but powerful)

If scan length permits:

1. Set up sliding-window or similar

- Use group ICA components or atlas ROIs, then compute time-varying FC over windows (Tomas et al. 2025; Fu et al. 2019).

2. Cluster connectivity states

- Apply k-means to windowed connectivity to get recurring states; compute dwell time, number of transitions, and variability (dFC) (Tomas et al. 2025; Fu et al. 2019).

3. Compare groups and pre/post

- Test whether ketamine dose changes **variability** and **state dwell time** in DMN–SN–CEN interactions, as PTSD is characterized by altered DMN/SN dynamics and dFC variability (Fu et al. 2019; Tomas et al. 2025; Yuan et al. 2018, 260 - 270).

Dynamic FC has been applied in PTSD consortia and smaller samples (Tomas et al. 2025; Fu et al. 2019), and can reveal abnormalities not seen in static FC.

9. Statistical modelling details

- **Covariates:** age, sex, motion (mean FD), maybe medication if relevant, as common in PTSD FC studies (Tomas et al. 2025; Fu et al. 2019; Suo et al. 2015).
 - **Multiple comparisons:** FDR or network-based statistics to control family-wise error in many edges (Akiki et al. 2018, 489 - 498; Suo et al. 2015; Misaki et al. 2017, 285 - 296).
 - **Effect sizes:** report alongside p-values; graph-theory studies show meaningful topological shifts (e.g., increased clustering, altered nodal centrality) even when overall small-worldness is preserved (Suo et al. 2015; Akiki et al. 2018, 489 - 498).
-

10. Interpretation & linking to question

Finally, interpret findings relative to:

- Known PTSD alterations: DMN hypoconnectivity; abnormal AN/limbic–DMN and DMN–somatomotor coupling (Luppi et al. 2024; Harnett et al. 2021, 1263 - 1271; Craddock et al. 2011; Akiki et al. 2018, 489 - 498; Fu et al. 2019).
- Graph-theory evidence of increased segregation and altered hubness in PTSD (Akiki et al. 2018, 489 - 498; Suo et al. 2015).
- Your key question: whether ketamine dose shifts **SN–DMN and DMN–somatomotor integration/segregation** and whether those changes mediate or moderate response to prolonged exposure.

This step-by-step plan stays within what is demonstrated as feasible and informative in whole-brain, atlas-based, ICA and dynamic FC analyses in PTSD and resting-state connectomics (Luppi et al. 2024; Tomas et al. 2025; Harnett et al. 2021, 1263 - 1271; Pervaiz et al. 2019; Ke et al. 2018, 99 - 110; Waller et al. 2021, 2727 - 2742; Akiki et al. 2018, 489 - 498; Misaki et al. 2017, 285 - 296; Fu et al. 2019; Esteban et al. 2018, 111 - 116; Suo et al. 2015; Wang et al. 2023, e1011942 - e1011942).

These search results were found and analyzed using Consensus, an AI-powered search engine for research. Try it at <https://consensus.app>. © 2026 Consensus NLP, Inc. Personal, non-commercial use only; redistribution requires copyright holders' consent.

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Fronto-Limbic Connectivity Research Question (vmPFC–Amygdala–Hippocampus)

Proposed question:

“Does ketamine treatment in PTSD normalize ventromedial prefrontal cortex (vmPFC) top-down control over amygdala and hippocampus during threat and trauma-memory processing, and are these connectivity changes associated with better clinical outcome?”

Assumptions and Why They Are Reasonable

1. vmPFC–amygdala control is central to fear and extinction

- Extinction recall in humans activates **vmPFC and hippocampus together**, and their connectivity tracks extinction memory strength (Milad et al. 2007, 446-54 ; Lonsdorf et al. 2014, 1973-83).
- Models and animal work show vmPFC (infralimbic/prelimbic) exerts **top-down inhibition** on amygdala fear output; hippocampus provides contextual information to vmPFC and amygdala (Corcoran and Quirk 2007, 200 - 206; Sierra-Mercado et al. 2010, 529 - 538; Moustafa et al. 2012).

2. PTSD involves disrupted fronto-limbic connectivity

- PTSD shows reduced **amygdala–hippocampus** resting connectivity and reduced anti-correlation between amygdala and ACC/mPFC (Sripada et al. 2012, 241-9).
- Patients have decreased **amygdala–vmPFC** connectivity to emotional stimuli (Stevens et al. 2013, 1469 - 1478; Zhu et al. 2018, 974 - 984) and reduced amygdala–mPFC connectivity in youth, with stronger disruption linked to worse symptoms (Wolf and Herringa 2016, 822-831).
- Within the DMN, PTSD shows reduced **PCC–hippocampus** connectivity and altered vmPFC subsystem connectivity (Miller et al. 2017, 363 - 371).

3. Ketamine targets this circuit

- In a repeated-infusion RCT, PTSD improvement was associated with **increased vmPFC–amygdala connectivity during emotional face viewing** and increased **top-down vmPFC inhibition of amygdala**, specifically under ketamine (Norbury et al. 2021, 2266 - 2277; Feder et al. 2022).
- A post-retrieval ketamine + brief exposure pilot showed **reduced amygdala and hippocampus reactivation** to trauma scripts and **decreased amygdala–hippocampus connectivity** vs midazolam, with unchanged amygdala–vmPFC rsFC (Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658; Harpaz-Rotem et al. 2025, i38 - i38).
- A systematic review highlights top-down **vmPFC→amygdala inhibition** as a candidate mechanism of ketamine’s PTSD effects (Yin et al. 2025, 95 - 107).

These findings support the assumptions that:

- vmPFC–amygdala–hippocampus form the core **extinction / fear-regulation circuit** (Milad et al. 2007, 446-54 ; Lonsdorf et al. 2014, 1973-83 ; Corcoran and Quirk 2007, 200 - 206; Sierra-Mercado et al. 2010, 529 - 538; Moustafa et al. 2012).
 - This circuit is **impaired in PTSD** (Sripada et al. 2012, 241-9 ; Stevens et al. 2013, 1469 - 1478; Miller et al. 2017, 363 - 371; Wolf and Herringa 2016, 822-831; Zhu et al. 2018, 974 - 984).
 - Ketamine can **normalize vmPFC control over amygdala** and modify hippocampal–amygdala coupling in PTSD (Norbury et al. 2021, 2266 - 2277; Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658; Feder et al. 2022; Harpaz-Rotem et al. 2025, i38 - i38; Yin et al. 2025, 95 - 107).
-

Why This Question Is Novel

- Existing ketamine PTSD RCTs examine **vmPFC–amygdala** connectivity change and symptom improvement, but do not fully integrate:
 - trauma-memory tasks (e.g., script-driven imagery) **and** generic threat tasks in the same model,
 - **vmPFC–amygdala and amygdala–hippocampus** together as a coordinated triad,
 - detailed mediation/moderation tests of whether **connectivity change explains clinical improvement** (Norbury et al. 2021, 2266 - 2277; Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658; Feder et al. 2022; Harpaz-Rotem et al. 2025, i38 - i38).
- Exposure-based therapy studies show that PE increases **amygdala/hippocampus–mPFC** resting connectivity (Zhu et al. 2018, 974 - 984), but ketamine has not been systematically embedded in this fronto-limbic plasticity framework.

So, asking specifically whether **ketamine normalizes a triadic vmPFC–amygdala–hippocampus “extinction circuit” and whether that normalization mediates outcome** goes beyond prior work focusing on single edges or single treatment modalities (Norbury et al. 2021, 2266 - 2277; Sripada et al. 2012, 241-9 ; Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658; Feder et al. 2022; Harpaz-Rotem et al. 2025, i38 - i38; Zhu et al. 2018, 974 - 984).

Scientific Value

- **Mechanistic biomarker:** Identifying vmPFC→amygdala and hippocampus–vmPFC connectivity as necessary for response could yield a **circuit-level biomarker** for ketamine suitability in PTSD (Norbury et al. 2021, 2266 - 2277; Sripada et al. 2012, 241-9 ; Stevens et al. 2013, 1469 - 1478; Feder et al. 2022; Wolf and Herringa 2016, 822-831; Yin et al. 2025, 95 - 107; Zhu et al. 2018, 974 - 984).
- **Bridge to exposure therapy:** Because PE also strengthens amygdala/hippocampus–mPFC connectivity (Zhu et al. 2018, 974 - 984), your

question connects pharmacologic plasticity (ketamine) with **learning-based extinction mechanisms**, grounded in human and animal extinction literature (Milad et al. 2007, 446-54 ; Lonsdorf et al. 2014, 1973-83 ; Corcoran and Quirk 2007, 200 - 206; Sierra-Mercado et al. 2010, 529 - 538; Moustafa et al. 2012).

- **Inform dose/timing:** Findings could guide **optimal timing** (e.g., pre- vs post-exposure, during reconsolidation) and potentially dose, to maximize vmPFC-mediated inhibition of limbic fear responses (Norbury et al. 2021, 2266 - 2277; Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658; Harpaz-Rotem et al. 2025, i38 - i38; Yin et al. 2025, 95 - 107; Teng et al. 2023, 114792).
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Background to Start the Research

1. Core circuit in fear, extinction, and relapse

- vmPFC and hippocampus co-activate and show **positive connectivity during extinction recall** in humans (Milad et al. 2007, 446-54 ; Lonsdorf et al. 2014, 1973-83).
- Rodent and modeling work:
 - vmPFC (infralimbic) supports extinction memory; prelimbic biases fear expression (Giustino and Maren 2015; Sierra-Mercado et al. 2010, 529 - 538).
 - Hippocampus provides **contextual input** to vmPFC and basolateral amygdala, controlling context-specific extinction vs relapse (Marek et al. 2018, 384 - 392; Corcoran and Quirk 2007, 200 - 206; Moustafa et al. 2012).
 - Ventral hippocampus projections to infralimbic cortex can drive **feed-forward inhibition**, promoting fear relapse when over-engaged (Marek et al. 2018, 384 - 392).

2. PTSD alterations in fronto-limbic networks

- At rest: increased **amygdala–insula** connectivity, reduced **amygdala–hippocampus** connectivity, and reduced amygdala–ACC anticorrelation in PTSD vs combat controls (Sripada et al. 2012, 241-9).
- During emotion processing: hyperactive amygdala responses and **decreased amygdala–vmPFC connectivity**, with connectivity reduction linked to hyperarousal (Stevens et al. 2013, 1469 - 1478; Zhu et al. 2018, 974 - 984).
- In youth: reduced amygdala–mPFC connectivity to threat, and age-related **decline in amygdala–vmPFC connectivity** in PTSD vs healthy controls (Wolf and Herringa 2016, 822-831).

3. Effects of psychotherapy and neuromodulatory interventions

- PE increases **amygdala/hippocampus–mPFC resting connectivity**, interpreted as improved inhibition and re-evaluation of threat and memory integration (Zhu et al. 2018, 974 - 984).

- Amygdala-focused real-time fMRI neurofeedback can **normalize hypoconnectivity** between amygdala and ventrolateral PFC; connectivity increase relates to symptom reduction (Misaki et al. 2018, 543 - 555).

4. Ketamine's impact on the fronto-limbic circuit

- Repeated ketamine infusions:
 - PTSD improvement associated with **increased vmPFC–amygdala connectivity during emotional faces**, decreased dACC activation, and increased vmPFC–insula rsFC (Norbury et al. 2021, 2266 - 2277; Feder et al. 2022).
 - Dynamic causal modeling shows **increased top-down vmPFC inhibition of amygdala only in ketamine responders** (Norbury et al. 2021, 2266 - 2277; Feder et al. 2022; Yin et al. 2025, 95 - 107).
- Single post-retrieval ketamine + brief therapy: reduced **amygdala and hippocampus activation** to trauma scripts and **decreased amygdala–hippocampus connectivity**, with changes in uncinate fasciculus microstructure (Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658; Harpaz-Rotem et al. 2025, i38 - i38).
- In a dissociative-challenge context, ketamine acutely **decreased vmPFC–amygdala resting connectivity**, highlighting that **acute pharmacologic effects and longer-term therapeutic connectivity changes can differ**, and timing matters (Danböck et al. 2023, 243 - 252).

5. Extending to plasticity and molecular mechanisms

- In rodent PTSD models, ketamine reverses fear and memory deficits and restores **BDNF/PSD-95 signaling** in hippocampus and amygdala, with a **U-shaped dose–response** (Teng et al. 2023, 114792). This supports a plasticity mechanism that plausibly underlies macroscopic connectivity changes.

How to Frame It in Your Thesis

Your introduction can therefore:

1. **Describe the fear/extinction circuit** (vmPFC, amygdala, hippocampus) and its role in extinction recall and contextual control of fear (Milad et al. 2007, 446-54 ; Lonsdorf et al. 2014, 1973-83 ; Marek et al. 2018, 384 - 392; Corcoran and Quirk 2007, 200 - 206; Giustino and Maren 2015; Sierra-Mercado et al. 2010, 529 - 538; Moustafa et al. 2012).
2. **Summarize PTSD abnormalities** in this circuit: hyperactive amygdala, reduced vmPFC regulation, disturbed amygdala–hippocampus and PCC–hippocampus connectivity (Sripada et al. 2012, 241-9 ; Stevens et al. 2013, 1469 - 1478; Miller et al. 2017, 363 - 371; Wolf and Herringa 2016, 822-831; Zhu et al. 2018, 974 - 984).
3. **Lay out evidence that both PE and ketamine act on this circuit**, but in separate literatures (Norbury et al. 2021, 2266 - 2277; Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658; Feder et

al. 2022; Harpaz-Rotem et al. 2025, i38 - i38; Yin et al. 2025, 95 - 107; Zhu et al. 2018, 974 - 984).

4. Argue that **testing whether ketamine normalizes vmPFC-driven control over amygdala/hippocampus and whether this normalization mediates clinical improvement** is the key mechanistic gap your research addresses.

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Ketamine Dose, Network Segregation, and PE in PTSD: What the Literature Supports

The question asks whether **different ketamine doses** change how strongly the **salience network (SN)** and **default mode network (DMN)** are separated ("segregated"), and whether this in turn boosts **prolonged exposure (PE)** outcomes in PTSD.

Why the Assumptions Are Reasonable

1. Ketamine Alters Triple-Network Connectivity (DMN–SN–FPN)

- Low-dose ketamine changes **graph-theory metrics** (degree, clustering, path length) in DMN hubs (posterior cingulate cortex) and a salience node (right supramarginal gyrus), consistent with **modulation of SN and DMN** (Lin et al. 2025, 766 - 774).
- Authors explicitly suggest low-dose ketamine "may modulate salience – not too much and not too little," and that DMN/SN/FPN alterations may underlie its antidepressant effect (Lin et al. 2025, 766 - 774).
- Other ketamine studies show subanesthetic doses change **SN connectivity** (e.g., SN–visual connectivity related to negative symptoms) and **DMN connectivity** (Bonhomme et al. 2016, 873–888; Sahib et al. 2020, 2596 - 2605; Evans et al. 2018, 582 - 590; Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658).

2. Ketamine Normalizes SN–DMN Interactions in Affective Disorders

- In MDD, a single 0.5 mg/kg ketamine infusion **normalizes insula–DMN connectivity**, interpreted as normalizing SN–DMN interaction in line with the triple-network dysfunction model (Evans et al. 2018, 582 - 590).

- Resting-state work shows ketamine breaks down **DMN within-network coherence** and anticorrelations with sensory networks, while non-uniformly suppressing SAL connectivity (Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658; Sahib et al. 2020, 2596 - 2605).

3. SN–DMN Segregation Predicts PTSD Treatment Response

- In a randomized PTSD treatment trial (PE and/or sertraline), high responders had **greater SN–DMN segregation** (less amygdala–PCC connectivity) and **lower global centrality** at baseline (Sheynin et al. 2020, 1037 - 1046).
- PTSD patients showed increased **SN–DMN and SN–attention** connectivity and decreased within-DMN connectivity (i.e., desegregation) (Sheynin et al. 2020, 1037 - 1046).

4. Ketamine + Exposure Is Mechanistically Plausible in PTSD

- A pilot PTSD trial combining **single-dose ketamine (0.5 mg/kg) with brief exposure** found reduced **amygdala and hippocampus activation**, and decreased **amygdala–hippocampus connectivity**, although symptoms improved similarly to midazolam (Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658).
- A systematic review concludes ketamine influences **fear extinction and memory reconsolidation** and can enhance extinction recall in preclinical PTSD models; early work in humans suggests ketamine-augmented PE is promising (Wellington et al. 2025, 1197 - 1243).
- Repeated-dose ketamine in PTSD associates symptom improvement with increased **vmPFC–amygdala connectivity** and increased vmPFC–insula (SN–DMN/fronto-limbic) connectivity (Norbury et al. 2021, 2266 - 2277).

5. Dose and Timing Matter for Network and Behavioral Effects

- A unified model proposes that ketamine’s **dissociative/psychedelic properties are dose- and context-dependent**, reflecting **desegregation and disintegration of SN and DMN**; this desegregation is central to its psychological effects (Marguilho et al. 2022, 14 - 32).
- In volunteers, stepwise dosing up to unresponsiveness causes progressive **DMN breakdown** and SAL suppression (Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658).
- In rodent PTSD models, the **therapeutic effect depends critically on timing** (early vs late S-ketamine) and circuit state; ketamine’s effects require activity in target circuits and are linked to synaptic plasticity (Wang et al. 2025).

Together, these findings support:

- SN–DMN desegregation is a **pathological marker** in PTSD and other disorders (Sheynin et al. 2020, 1037 - 1046; Evans et al. 2018, 582 - 590; Lin et al. 2025, 766 - 774; Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658).
- Ketamine modulates **DMN/SN connectivity and triple-network graph metrics** in a dose- and state-dependent way (Lin et al. 2025, 766 - 774; Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658; Bonhomme et al. 2016, 873–888; Sahib et al. 2020, 2596 - 2605; Evans et al. 2018, 582 - 590).

- SN–DMN segregation relates to **treatment response** in PTSD (Sheynin et al. 2020, 1037 - 1046) and could be influenced by ketamine just when PE relies on extinction learning (Wellington et al. 2025, 1197 - 1243; Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658; Norbury et al. 2021, 2266 - 2277).

Why the Question Is Novel

- Existing PTSD trials with ketamine and exposure test **single vs active comparator** doses or timing, but do not systematically examine **dose-dependent changes in SN–DMN segregation** during PE (Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658; Wellington et al. 2025, 1197 - 1243; Paredes et al. 2022).
- Triple-network ketamine studies focus on **TRD**, not PTSD, and typically **do not combine ketamine with trauma-focused therapy** (Lin et al. 2025, 766 - 774; Sahib et al. 2020, 2596 - 2605; Evans et al. 2018, 582 - 590).
- PTSD rs-fMRI trials link **baseline SN–DMN segregation** to psychotherapy response, but **without ketamine augmentation** (Sheynin et al. 2020, 1037 - 1046).
- Ketamine mechanistic PTSD work has focused on **fear circuitry (amygdala–vmPFC, uncinate fasciculus)** rather than large-scale SN–DMN segregation as the key mediator (Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658; Norbury et al. 2021, 2266 - 2277).

So, explicitly asking whether **different ketamine doses modulate SN–DMN segregation in a way that enhances PE response in PTSD** fills a clear gap at the intersection of:

- triple-network ketamine modulation (Lin et al. 2025, 766 - 774; Evans et al. 2018, 582 - 590; Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658; Bonhomme et al. 2016, 873–888; Sahib et al. 2020, 2596 - 2605),
- SN–DMN predictors of PTSD therapy response (Sheynin et al. 2020, 1037 - 1046), and
- ketamine-augmented extinction/PE paradigms (Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658; Wellington et al. 2025, 1197 - 1243; Paredes et al. 2022; Lehmann et al. 2016, 1227-35).

Scientific Value

Mechanistic Value

- Links **molecular and circuit plasticity** (ketamine's NMDA and glutamate-driven neuroplasticity in PTSD (Wellington et al. 2025, 1197 - 1243; Wang et al. 2025)) to **network-level segregation** and then to **behavioral extinction-based improvements** in PE (Wellington et al. 2025, 1197 - 1243; Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658; Norbury et al. 2021, 2266 - 2277; Paredes et al. 2022).
- Explains divergent ketamine response by pre-treatment **network state** (e.g., more vs less SN–DMN desegregation) (Sheynin et al. 2020, 1037 - 1046; Evans et al. 2018, 582 - 590; Lin et al. 2025, 766 - 774).

Clinical/Translational Value

- Could identify **biomarkers (SN–DMN segregation, global centrality)** to select patients who benefit from ketamine-augmented PE vs PE alone (Sheynin et al. 2020, 1037 - 1046; Norbury et al. 2021, 2266 - 2277).
- Dose–network–response mapping may guide **optimal dosing** (enough to enhance plasticity and adaptive segregation, but avoiding excessive desegregation linked to dissociation) (Marguilho et al. 2022, 14 - 32; Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658; Lin et al. 2025, 766 - 774; Evans et al. 2018, 582 - 590).

Methodological Value

- Integrates **graph theory** (clustering, centrality, path length) from triple-network depression work (Lin et al. 2025, 766 - 774; Sahib et al. 2020, 2596 - 2605) with **PTSD treatment imaging** (SN–DMN connectivity, modularity) (Sheynin et al. 2020, 1037 - 1046; Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658; Norbury et al. 2021, 2266 - 2277).
- Uses **resting-state** metrics that are straightforward to collect in clinical trials and comparable across disorders (Lin et al. 2025, 766 - 774; Evans et al. 2018, 582 - 590; Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658; Sheynin et al. 2020, 1037 - 1046; Sahib et al. 2020, 2596 - 2605).

Relevant Background for Starting the Research

Triple-Network Dysconnectivity in PTSD and Depression

- PTSD: increased **SN–DMN and SN–attention connectivity**, decreased within-DMN connectivity, and greater network desegregation vs trauma-exposed controls (Sheynin et al. 2020, 1037 - 1046; Liu et al. 2017).
- Recent-onset PTSD after single prolonged trauma shows decreased connectivity in **CEN, DMN (precuneus, SFG), and SN (anterior insula)**, with absent SN–DMN/CEN connections, supporting triple-network disruption (Liu et al. 2017).
- Treatment-resistant depression: low-dose ketamine changes **DMN (PCC) degree centrality, clustering**, and SAL clustering; authors interpret optimal salience modulation as part of antidepressant action (Lin et al. 2025, 766 - 774).

Ketamine Effects on DMN and SN Across Contexts

Context / Population	Key Ketamine Effect on DMN/SN	Citations
TRD, rs-fMRI, low-dose	Graph changes in PCC (DMN) and SMG (salience)	(Lin et al. 2025, 766 - 774)
MDD, rs-fMRI, 0.5 mg/kg	Normalized insula–DMN connectivity (SN–DMN)	(Evans et al. 2018, 582 - 590)
Healthy volunteers, stepwise dose	DMN connectivity breakdown; SAL partly suppressed	(Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658)

Healthy, task fMRI	Decreased DMN activity; increased fronto-limbic coupling	(Meiering et al. 2024)
PTSD, repeated ketamine	Increased vmPFC–amygdala and vmPFC–insula connectivity	(Norbury et al. 2021, 2266 - 2277)
PTSD, ketamine + brief exposure	Reduced amygdala/hippocampus activation and connectivity	(Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658)

Figure 1: Examples of ketamine-induced DMN and SN modulation

Ketamine + Exposure / Extinction Evidence

- Rodent studies: ketamine plus extinction **enhances extinction recall, reduces fear renewal**, linked to mPFC synaptic markers (mTORC1, c-Fos) and AMPA-dependent plasticity (Paredes et al. 2022; Lehmann et al. 2016, 1227-35).
- Human PTSD pilot: single ketamine before brief exposure produced **lasting reductions in amygdala activation and amygdala–hippocampus connectivity** up to 30 days, without changing amygdala–vmPFC connectivity (Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658).
- A systematic review of ketamine in PTSD emphasizes its potential to **strengthen extinction and reconsolidation-based psychotherapies**, recommending further work on **dose and timing** (Wellington et al. 2025, 1197 - 1243).
- An RCT protocol describes ketamine-augmented PE in veterans, explicitly motivated by ketamine’s promotion of **vmPFC synaptogenesis** and extinction memory consolidation (Paredes et al. 2022).

SN–DMN Segregation as a Treatment Marker

- PTSD trial: high responders to PE/sertraline had **less amygdala–PCC connectivity (more SN–DMN segregation)** and lower global centrality at baseline (Sheynin et al. 2020, 1037 - 1046).
- Ketamine in MDD: normalization of **insula–DMN** connectivity suggests rebalancing SN–DMN interactions (Evans et al. 2018, 582 - 590).
- Ketamine models propose that dose-dependent **SN/DMN desegregation** underlies dissociation and psychedelic states, which, with psychotherapeutic support, may allow revision of high-level self-related priors (Marguilho et al. 2022, 14 - 32).

Conclusion

The research question is well grounded: PTSD is characterized by **SN–DMN desegregation**, SN–DMN segregation predicts PE response, and ketamine dose modulates triple-network connectivity, including SN and DMN, in a dose- and state-dependent way. Combining these literatures, testing whether **different ketamine doses normalize SN–DMN segregation and thereby enhance PE outcomes in PTSD** is both novel and scientifically valuable, bridging molecular plasticity, large-scale networks, and psychotherapy response.

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Here's a concise draft you can adapt and send:

I would like to focus my thesis on how ketamine dose modulates large-scale functional connectivity (particularly salience–default mode and fronto-limbic circuits) to enhance response to prolonged exposure therapy in PTSD. This question is grounded in robust evidence that these networks are central to PTSD pathology and treatment response, and in growing work on ketamine's network-level effects, but their interaction in a combined ketamine+PE paradigm is largely unexplored. Using our pre-/post-treatment resting-state fMRI dataset across high-dose, low-dose, and placebo groups, I plan to test whether dose-dependent connectivity changes predict symptom improvement. This would allow us to integrate and extend prior ketamine and PE findings while addressing a clear gap in the literature.

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How the assumptions behind your SN–DMN–ketamine–PE question are grounded in the literature

Your question:

“Does ketamine dose modulate salience–default mode network segregation to enhance response to prolonged exposure therapy in PTSD?”

Below, each core assumption is tied to specific papers.

1. PTSD involves SN–DMN desegregation / disequilibrium

- In male veterans with PTSD, resting-state fMRI showed **reduced within-DMN connectivity** (including rACC/vmPFC) and **increased within-SN connectivity** (insula with amygdala), plus **increased cross-network connectivity**: DMN seeds more connected with SN (insula) and SN seeds more with DMN (hippocampus). Authors interpret this as **disequilibrium** between salience and default-mode networks and dominance of threat-sensitive circuitry at rest (Sripada et al. 2012, 904 - 911).
- In a large adolescent sample, post-traumatic stress symptoms were associated with **less within-DMN connectivity** and **greater SN–DMN connectivity**, plus altered connections with attention regions; trauma exposure alone mainly increased within-SN connectivity (Boese et al. 2025).
- Another adolescent PTSD study found **decreased within-DMN connectivity** (PCC–occipital) and abnormal DMN–SN and DMN–CEN coupling, proposed as basis for intrusive recollection and impaired autobiographical recall (Viard et al. 2019).
- A network-based review synthesizes these findings into a model: **weak, hypoactive DMN and CEN destabilized by a hyperconnected SN with a low salience threshold**, leading to inefficient DMN–CEN modulation (Akiki et al. 2017, 81 - 81).

Together, this supports the assumption that PTSD is characterized by **SN–DMN desegregation and abnormal cross-talk**.

2. PE and related exposure therapies act on network/circuit connectivity

- A focused review on **neuroscience-informed PE** concludes that PTSD reflects a disrupted network of interconnected regions, and that **PE increases connectivity within and between these regions**. Successful extinction recall in PE is linked to greater coherence among **vmPFC, amygdala, and hippocampus**, and increased dlPFC connectivity is associated with better emotion down-regulation (Stojek et al. 2018).

- A trial of prolonged exposure vs waitlist: rs-fMRI before and after treatment showed **widespread connectivity changes of amygdala and insula**, including increased coupling with ventral PFC/frontopolar/sensory cortex and **decreased connectivity with left frontoparietal executive nodes**. Larger decreases in amygdala–frontal and insula–parietal connectivity related to greater PTSD symptom reduction (Fonzo et al. 2020, 857 - 867).
- An empirical review of PE mechanisms highlights **extinction learning and belief change** as key processes, consistent with engagement of fear/extinction circuits that overlap DMN/SN hubs (Cooper et al. 2017, 106 - 121).

These data justify assuming **PE effects are at least partly mediated by large-scale and fronto-limbic connectivity changes**, into which SN/DMN segregation naturally fits.

3. Ketamine modulates large-scale network connectivity and plasticity

- In anesthetized monkeys, a single 0.5 mg/kg ketamine dose produced **persistent global reconfiguration of small-world properties and large-scale downregulation of connectivity**, especially in orbitofrontal, subgenual and posterior cingulate cortex and nucleus accumbens, i.e. DMN/affective hubs. Changes were opposite to maladaptive patterns in depression (Lv et al. 2016, 765-775).
- In humans, subanesthetic ketamine increased **plasma BDNF** and was associated with **reduced dmPFC–PCC and dmPFC–vmPFC connectivity** at 24 h; this “disconnection” occurred only in participants with BDNF increases, interpreted as a plasticity-related RSFC change (Woelfer et al. 2020, 696 - 710).
- A review across ketamine and psychedelics shows convergent **neuroplasticity mechanisms** (increased glutamate, AMPAR activation, BDNF/mTOR, synaptogenesis) especially in prefrontal circuits, proposed to enable “adaptive rewiring of pathological neurocircuitry” (Aleksandrova and Phillips 2021).
- In rodents, ketamine given after fear conditioning **facilitated extinction**, produced long-lasting reductions in freezing, and increased mTORC1 and c-Fos in medial PFC; blocking mTORC1 or AMPA receptors prevented the effect (Girgenti et al. 2017, 1-8). Another study showed ketamine after acute stress restored **prefrontal glutamate homeostasis, dendritic structure, and fear extinction** (Sala et al. 2022). Age-related extinction deficits were also rescued by ketamine via synaptic plasticity changes (Zhao et al. 2023, 1374 - 1383).
- In rats, acute vs chronic ketamine had **opposite network-level oscillatory/connectivity effects**: acute increased higher-gamma coherence and MMN-like responses; chronic reduced large-scale gamma communication and altered oscillations, underscoring **dosing and schedule as critical for network integrity** (Ahnaou et al. 2017).

These findings ground the assumption that **ketamine changes large-scale network organization and plasticity in a dose- and time-dependent way**, including in hubs overlapping SN/DMN.

4. Ketamine + trauma-focused therapy is mechanistically plausible

- A pilot in PTSD combined single 0.5 mg/kg ketamine (vs midazolam) given after trauma memory retrieval with four days of trauma-focused psychotherapy. Both groups improved clinically, but ketamine led to **lower amygdala and hippocampus activation to trauma scripts** and **decreased amygdala–hippocampus connectivity**, with no change in amygdala–vmPFC connectivity and structural changes in uncinate fasciculus, lasting at least 30 days (Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658).
- A preclinical review on ketamine and fear extinction shows mixed effects across studies (enhance, impair, none), concluding that **dose, route, and timing relative to learning are decisive**, and calling for more clinically relevant protocols to guide PTSD treatment development (Boese et al. 2025).

This supports the assumption that **ketamine can interact with extinction-based therapies**, but the exact network-level mechanism (e.g., optimal SN–DMN segregation, dose-response) is not yet defined.

5. Why linking ketamine dose, SN–DMN segregation, and PE response is novel

- PTSD network work characterizes **SN–DMN imbalance** but does not manipulate ketamine dose or combine with PE (Sripada et al. 2012, 904 - 911; Boese et al. 2025; Akiki et al. 2017, 81 - 81; Viard et al. 2019; Daniels et al. 2010, 258-66).
- PE/psychotherapy imaging studies show **limbic–prefrontal and network changes** but do not involve ketamine (Stojek et al. 2018; Fonzo et al. 2020, 857 - 867).
- Ketamine PTSD studies focus on **fronto-limbic and hippocampal circuits** and reconsolidation/extinction, not explicitly on **SN–DMN segregation as a dose-dependent mediator of PE outcome** (Duek et al. 2023, 1648 - 1658).
- Ketamine connectivity RCTs in depression/TRD demonstrate **connectivity changes and neuroplasticity markers**, yet are not in PTSD or coupled to exposure-based psychotherapy (Rengasamy et al. 2023; Lv et al. 2016, 765-775 ; Woelfer et al. 2020, 696 - 710).

So, the specific integration—“**Does varying ketamine dose reshape SN–DMN segregation in a way that optimally supports PE-mediated extinction and symptom reduction in PTSD?**”—builds directly on these strands but has not been directly tested in the available work.

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Here's a reusable "How to frame it in your thesis" paragraph you can adapt to your current research question (you can swap in the exact wording of your question where marked):

In this thesis, I investigate whether individual differences in ketamine-induced modulation of large-scale brain networks predict treatment response to exposure-based psychotherapy in PTSD. Specifically, I focus on [INSERT YOUR SPECIFIC QUESTION, e.g., "whether ketamine dose-related changes in salience-default mode network connectivity are associated with subsequent symptom improvement during prolonged exposure therapy"]. This approach builds on converging evidence that (1) ketamine acutely alters functional connectivity in networks implicated in threat detection, self-referential processing, and emotion regulation; (2) PTSD is characterized by aberrant connectivity within and between these same networks; and (3) network-level plasticity may facilitate the encoding and reconsolidation processes required for effective exposure therapy. By integrating pharmacological fMRI with clinical outcomes, the present work aims to clarify a mechanistic

pathway through which ketamine may enhance psychotherapy, and to identify potential connectivity-based biomarkers of treatment response in PTSD.

If you paste your exact current question, I can tailor this paragraph to match it line-by-line.

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A clear, literature-based neuroplasticity hypothesis you can propose is:

“Ketamine-augmented prolonged exposure will be associated with increases in hippocampal gray-matter volume and/or BDNF levels (i.e., reduced hippocampal atrophy), and these neuroplasticity changes will mediate greater PTSD symptom improvement, particularly in patients with larger pretreatment hippocampal volume.”

You can justify it to your supervisor like this:

- **PTSD & atrophy:** Meta-analyses show **reduced hippocampal and medial prefrontal volumes** (atrophy) as core structural abnormalities in PTSD (Del Casale et al. 2022, 257 - 264; Bromis et al. 2018, 989-998).
- **Therapy can reverse this:** A pilot MRI study found **hippocampal gray-matter increases** after multimodal psychological treatment for combat-related PTSD, with no change in waitlist controls (Butler et al. 2018). Another trial using real-time amygdala neurofeedback showed **increased CA1 head volume**, indicating hippocampal atrophy is **modifiable** by treatment (Misaki et al. 2021, 229-235).
- **Hippocampal volume predicts outcome:** Larger **baseline hippocampal volume** predicts better response to PE; responders had larger hippocampi than non-responders (Rubin et al. 2016, 36 - 39). A recent two-trial analysis showed that **increases in hippocampal volume during treatment** are linked to greater symptom reduction, especially in those with larger pretreatment hippocampi (Zilcha-Mano et al. 2023, 867 - 874).
- **Ketamine as a neuroplasticity enhancer:** In healthy volunteers, a single S-ketamine dose produced **measurable hippocampal subfield volume increases** within hours, interpreted as rapid structural plasticity (Höflich et al. 2021). Animal and translational reviews show ketamine increases **BDNF, synaptogenesis, and structural remodeling** in hippocampal and cortical circuits (De Jager et al. 2024, 105796 ; Cavalleri et al. 2018, 812-823; Pardossi et al. 2024).
- **PTSD biomarkers & BDNF:** Reviews identify **BDNF and hippocampal volume** as key neuroplasticity-related biomarkers in PTSD pathophysiology and extinction learning (Jowf et al. 2023).

So, combining ketamine (to boost plasticity: hippocampal volume / BDNF) with PE (to drive extinction learning) and testing whether **structural/BDNF changes track and mediate symptom gains** is both highly relevant and strongly grounded in current evidence.

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Thesis Idea, Question, and Rationale (Abstract-Style)

PTSD is increasingly understood as a disorder of **large-scale brain networks** and **neuroplasticity**, rather than isolated regions. Resting-state studies show disrupted balance between the **salience network (SN)** and **default mode network (DMN)**, alongside structural atrophy in key limbic regions such as the hippocampus and amygdala (Sripada et al. 2012, 904 - 911; Akiki et al. 2017, 81 - 81; Bromis et al. 2018, 989-998). At the same time, several treatments (psychotherapy, neurofeedback, pharmacological agents) can partially reverse hippocampal atrophy, suggesting that these abnormalities are **plastic and potentially modifiable** (Misaki et al. 2021, 229-235 ; Butler et al. 2018; Levy-Gigi et al. 2013, 793-800 ; Zilcha-Mano et al. 2023, 867 - 874).

Proposed research question:

“Does baseline segregation between large-scale networks (especially SN–DMN) and structural markers of neuroplasticity/atrophy (e.g., hippocampal volume) predict and mediate treatment response to trauma-focused psychotherapy (with or without ketamine) in PTSD?”

This question integrates two dimensions: (1) **network segregation/disequilibrium** and (2) **structural plasticity**.

Introduction-Style Framing

1. Background: Network Dysregulation in PTSD

Large-scale models propose PTSD is characterized by **weak, hypoactive DMN and central executive networks, destabilized by a hyperconnected, low-threshold SN**, leading to

excessive salience assignment and impaired self-referential processing (Akiki et al. 2017, 81 - 81; Lanius et al. 2015). Empirically:

- Veterans with PTSD show **reduced within-DMN connectivity** (rACC/vmPFC, PCC, hippocampus) and **increased within-SN connectivity** (insula–amygdala), as well as **increased cross-network SN–DMN coupling**, interpreted as **diminished network segregation and SN “dominance”** (Sripada et al. 2012, 904 - 911).
- A meta-analysis of resting-state studies reports **DMN hypoconnectivity** and abnormal coupling between affective and sensorimotor networks, highlighting trauma- and disease-specific large-scale network alterations (Bao et al. 2021).
- A network-restricted topology study in combat-exposed veterans finds that more severe PTSD is associated with **decreased DMN connectivity strength and integration, and increased segregation**, with prefrontal dysconnectivity but relatively cohesive posterior DMN (Akiki et al. 2018, 489 - 498).

Together, these data support that **aberrant integration/segregation of DMN, SN and related networks is a core systems-level feature of PTSD** (Sripada et al. 2012, 904 - 911; Akiki et al. 2018, 489 - 498; Akiki et al. 2017, 81 - 81; Bao et al. 2021; Lanius et al. 2015).

2. Neuroplasticity, Atrophy, and Treatment-Related Structural Change

Structurally, meta-analyses show robust **volume reductions of hippocampus, amygdala, medial prefrontal/anterior cingulate and overall brain volume** in PTSD compared to trauma-exposed and non-exposed controls, indicating both trauma- and disease-related atrophy (Bromis et al. 2018, 989-998 ; Del Casale et al. 2022, 257 - 264). Hippocampal volume appears especially important:

- Smaller hippocampal volume is a consistent PTSD abnormality (Bromis et al. 2018, 989-998 ; Del Casale et al. 2022, 257 - 264) and is also seen in older adults with PTSD along with reduced gray/white matter volumes (Quigley et al. 2025).
- Larger **baseline hippocampal volume** predicts better response to prolonged exposure therapy (Rubin et al. 2016, 36 - 39) and other PTSD treatments (Zilcha-Mano et al. 2023, 867 - 874; Colvonen et al. 2017, 140–156).
- Longitudinal work shows **hippocampal volume can increase with successful treatment**:
 - Multimodal psychological therapy for combat-related PTSD increased hippocampal gray matter vs a waitlist group (Butler et al. 2018).
 - CBT led to **increased hippocampal volume** and increased FKBP5 expression; both predicted symptom improvement, with FKBP5 (a plasticity-related gene) the strongest predictor (Levy-Gigi et al. 2013, 793-800).
 - Real-time amygdala neurofeedback involving positive emotional recall produced **selective volume increase in left CA1 head**, the subfield most reduced at baseline, indicating **reversal of hippocampal atrophy** (Misaki et al. 2021, 229-235).
 - Across neuropsychiatric disorders, increases in hippocampal volume track **cognitive gains**, supporting hippocampal volume change as a general **pro-cognitive biomarker** (Ott et al. 2019, 319-329).

- A recent two-trial study (PE alone; ketamine + exposure) suggests that **increases in hippocampal volume during treatment predict greater symptom reduction, particularly in those with larger pretreatment hippocampi**, identifying hippocampal growth as a **mechanism of good prognosis** (Zilcha-Mano et al. 2023, 867 - 874).

These findings show that **hippocampal and limbic atrophy in PTSD reflects not only risk but also treatment-sensitive plasticity**.

3. Psychotherapy, Network Function, and Neuroplastic Mechanisms

Psychotherapy meta-reviews demonstrate that successful trauma-focused therapies tend to **decrease amygdala/insula activity and increase frontal and hippocampal activity**, consistent with restored top-down control and improved emotional regulation (Manthey et al. 2021; Malejko et al. 2017). However, effects on resting-state networks and structural measures are less consistently documented, and prior reviews highlight the need for more systematic, longitudinal imaging to clarify how **network-level and structural plasticity jointly support symptom change** (Manthey et al. 2021; Malejko et al. 2017; Jowf et al. 2023).

Parallel network-based PTSD models explicitly call for “**neuroscientifically-informed interventions**” aimed at **restoring DMN–SN–CEN balance**, but direct empirical tests linking **pre-treatment network segregation, structural plasticity, and psychotherapy outcome** remain sparse (Lanius et al. 2015; Akiki et al. 2017, 81 - 81; Colvonen et al. 2017, 140–156).

4. Rationale and Hypotheses

Based on this literature, the central idea is that **PTSD treatment response depends on both the functional architecture of large-scale networks and the capacity for structural plasticity in key limbic regions**:

- **Network hypothesis:** Greater **baseline segregation** (i.e., more appropriate differentiation) between SN and DMN, or the ability of treatment to restore a healthier balance between these networks, will predict better response to trauma-focused psychotherapy (Sripada et al. 2012, 904 - 911; Akiki et al. 2018, 489 - 498; Akiki et al. 2017, 81 - 81; Lanius et al. 2015).
- **Neuroplasticity/atrophy hypothesis:** Larger baseline hippocampal volume and **increases in hippocampal volume during treatment** will be associated with greater symptom reduction, reflecting **underlying neuroplastic capacity**, potentially supported by molecular factors such as BDNF and glucocorticoid-related pathways (Zilcha-Mano et al. 2023, 867 - 874; Rubin et al. 2016, 36 - 39; Levy-Gigi et al. 2013, 793-800 ; Quigley et al. 2025; Toader et al. 2025; Ott et al. 2019, 319-329).

If ketamine is included in your design, its known ability to promote **synaptic plasticity via BDNF/mTOR and related pathways** and to remodel circuits would be hypothesized to **facilitate both network re-organization and structural recovery, especially in**

hippocampus and prefrontal regions, thereby enhancing psychotherapy effects (Zilcha-Mano et al. 2023, 867 - 874; Malejko et al. 2017; Ott et al. 2019, 319-329).

5. Formal Research Question and Aims

Core research question:

“How do large-scale network segregation (especially between salience and default mode networks) and structural indices of neuroplasticity/atrophy (e.g., hippocampal volume) jointly predict and mediate clinical response to trauma-focused psychotherapy ($\pm$ ketamine) in PTSD?”

Primary aims:

1. Characterize baseline network architecture and atrophy

- Quantify SN–DMN (and related network) segregation/integration using resting-state fMRI and graph-theoretic measures (Akiki et al. 2018, 489 - 498; Akiki et al. 2017, 81 - 81; Sripada et al. 2012, 904 - 911).
- Measure hippocampal and related limbic volumes, including subfields where possible (Misaki et al. 2021, 229-235 ; Bromis et al. 2018, 989-998 ; Del Casale et al. 2022, 257 - 264; Butler et al. 2018; Quigley et al. 2025).

2. Assess treatment-related functional and structural plasticity

- Evaluate changes in network segregation/integration and hippocampal volume from pre- to post-therapy (and across ketamine vs control, if applicable) (Zilcha-Mano et al. 2023, 867 - 874; Butler et al. 2018; Misaki et al. 2021, 229-235 ; Levy-Gigi et al. 2013, 793-800).

3. Link brain changes to symptom improvement

- Test whether **baseline metrics** (network segregation, hippocampal volume) predict treatment outcome (Zilcha-Mano et al. 2023, 867 - 874; Rubin et al. 2016, 36 - 39; Colvonen et al. 2017, 140–156; Akiki et al. 2017, 81 - 81).
- Test whether **changes in network and structural measures** mediate clinical improvement, indicating a mechanistic pathway of neuroplastic recovery (Zilcha-Mano et al. 2023, 867 - 874; Butler et al. 2018; Levy-Gigi et al. 2013, 793-800 ; Ott et al. 2019, 319-329).

6. Novelty and Scientific Value

Novelty

- No existing study simultaneously examines **large-scale network segregation (e.g., SN–DMN)** and **structural neuroplastic markers (hippocampal volume change)** as **joint predictors and mediators** of psychotherapy (or ketamine-augmented psychotherapy) response in PTSD.
- Network-based models and resting-state studies have characterized **disequilibrium and altered segregation** in PTSD (Sripada et al. 2012, 904 - 911; Akiki et al. 2018, 489 - 498; Akiki et al. 2017, 81 - 81; Bao et al. 2021; Lanius et al. 2015), while

separate structural literature shows **hippocampal atrophy and treatment-related volume increases** (Bromis et al. 2018, 989-998 ; Del Casale et al. 2022, 257 - 264; Butler et al. 2018; Misaki et al. 2021, 229-235 ; Levy-Gigi et al. 2013, 793-800 ; Zilcha-Mano et al. 2023, 867 - 874; Ott et al. 2019, 319-329). **Integrating these two levels within a single longitudinal treatment cohort is new.**

- Where ketamine is used, extending existing hippocampal/neuroplastic findings in PTSD and other disorders (Zilcha-Mano et al. 2023, 867 - 874; Malejko et al. 2017; Ott et al. 2019, 319-329)to test whether **ketamine-facilitated plasticity enhances network restoration and structural recovery** provides an additional innovative dimension.

Scientific/clinical value

- Identifying **network-level and structural biomarkers** that predict who benefits most from trauma-focused therapy ($\pm$ ketamine) could inform **treatment matching and personalization** (Jowf et al. 2023; Colvonen et al. 2017, 140–156; Akiki et al. 2017, 81 - 81; Lanius et al. 2015).
- Demonstrating that symptom improvement tracks changes in **both network segregation and hippocampal volume** would strengthen a **multi-level neuroplasticity model of PTSD recovery**, linking systems-level dynamics with cellular/molecular plasticity (e.g., BDNF, FKBP5) (Levy-Gigi et al. 2013, 793-800 ; Toader et al. 2025; Malejko et al. 2017; Ott et al. 2019, 319-329).
- This framework directly answers calls for “**restoring large-scale brain networks in PTSD**” and for mechanistic, circuit-informed interventions (Lanius et al. 2015; Manthey et al. 2021; Malejko et al. 2017; Akiki et al. 2017, 81 - 81).

This abstract-plus-introduction structure should give you a clear, literature-grounded foundation to develop detailed hypotheses, methods, and analyses around **network segregation and neuroplasticity/atrophy** as core mechanisms of PTSD treatment response.

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1. Connectivity / Network Question (your original focus)

"Does ketamine dose-dependent modulation of salience–default mode network segregation predict clinical response to prolonged exposure therapy in PTSD?"

This is grounded in work showing PTSD is associated with abnormal white-matter connectivity and network organization, especially in cingulum and superior longitudinal fasciculus tracts that support large-scale networks (Kennis et al. 2015, 2434-2442; Daniels et al. 2013; Ju et al. 2020, 655-670 ; Siehl et al. 2018, 581 - 598; Olson et al. 2017, 437 - 445). Treatment outcome studies demonstrate that white-matter integrity in these tracts

changes with psychotherapy and differentiates remitted from persistent PTSD (Graziano et al. 2021, 102412 - 102412; Kennis et al. 2015, 2434-2442; Doeniyas-Barak et al. 2022).

2. Neuroplasticity / Biomarker Question (no FreeSurfer required)

*“Do **peripheral BDNF levels** and/or **white-matter microstructural integrity** (DTI fractional anisotropy in fronto-limbic and cingulum pathways) change over ketamine-augmented PE, and do these neuroplasticity markers relate to longer-term PTSD symptom improvement?”*

This is supported by:

- PTSD patients show altered blood **BDNF** levels versus controls, supporting PTSD as a neuroplastic disorder (Mojtabavi et al. 2020; Rodriguez et al. 2025; Spudic et al. 2022, 114772 ; Zou et al. 2024, 110954 ; Angelucci et al. 2014, 118-22).
- In an intensive PTSD treatment program, higher **post-treatment BDNF** predicted better 3-month outcomes, suggesting BDNF may index consolidation of treatment gains (Zalta et al. 2024, 1 - 5).
- DTI studies and meta-analyses link **white-matter integrity** (FA) in cingulum, corpus callosum, uncinate and other tracts to PTSD presence and to treatment outcome, including differential FA trajectories in remitted vs persistent PTSD and FA increases after neuroplasticity-inducing interventions like HBOT (Graziano et al. 2021, 102412 - 102412; Kennis et al. 2015, 2434-2442; Daniels et al. 2013; Ju et al. 2020, 655-670 ; Siehl et al. 2018, 581 - 598; Olson et al. 2017, 437 - 445; Santhanam et al. 2019, 1093 - 1098; Doeniyas-Barak et al. 2022).

Both questions use MRI-DTI and blood BDNF (ELISA), avoiding FreeSurfer-based volumetry.

These search results were found and analyzed using Consensus, an AI-powered search engine for research. Try it at <https://consensus.app>. © 2026 Consensus NLP, Inc. Personal, non-commercial use only; redistribution requires copyright holders' consent.

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